

Workshop Technical Report

Africa-Asia Biosciences Challenge Fund (AABCF) Southeast Asia Stakeholder Consultation Workshop:

Advancing Climate-Smart Livestock through Science, Innovation, and Partnership

Hanoi, Vietnam, 23-27 March 2026



Executive summary

The Africa-Asia Bioscience Challenge Fund (AABCF) Workshop in Hanoi, Vietnam brought together scientists, policymakers, and development practitioners from Africa, Australia and Southeast Asia to address the growing challenges at the intersection of climate change, animal health, and livestock systems. The workshop aimed to strengthen technical capacity, foster cross-regional collaboration, and generate actionable solutions for climate-resilient and sustainable livestock systems.

Across multiple days of technical sessions, field visits, and collaborative synthesis exercises, participants identified critical systemic challenges, including climate-induced disease risks, weak surveillance systems, limited access to technology and finance, and fragmented policy frameworks. The workshop emphasized the importance of adopting a One Health approach, integrating human, animal, and environmental health, as well as advancing climate-smart livestock systems that balance productivity, adaptation, and mitigation.

Key findings highlight that:

- Climate change is a major driver of livestock system vulnerability, influencing disease dynamics, productivity, and resource availability.
- Data and surveillance gaps significantly limit effective decision-making and early warning systems.
- Smallholder farmers face structural barriers, including limited access to finance, markets, and extension services.
- Technological innovations such as genomics, precision livestock tools, and improved waste management systems offer significant potential but remain underutilized due to capacity and infrastructure constraints.
- Regional collaboration enhances learning, innovation, and scalability of solutions.

The workshop resulted in a shared regional vision for livestock transformation, emphasizing integrated systems approaches, strengthened institutional coordination, targeted investments, and sustained capacity building. It also laid the foundation for future collaborative research, policy alignment, and development of bankable investment opportunities.

1. Introduction

Livestock systems play a critical role in supporting food security, nutrition, and livelihoods across Africa and Asia. However, these systems are increasingly challenged by climate variability, emerging and re-emerging diseases, environmental degradation, and market pressures.

The AABCF southeast Asia Stakeholder consultation workshop held in Hanoi, Vietnam was designed to respond to these challenges by strengthening scientific and technical capacity, promoting cross-country and cross-disciplinary collaboration and facilitating evidence-based solutions for sustainable livestock systems

The workshop combined technical training, applied learning, and collaborative synthesis, creating a platform for participants to bridge science, policy, and practice.

2. Objectives of the workshop

The workshop aimed to expose and build capacity in the participants around:

- The climate smart livestock agenda incorporating productivity, adaptation and mitigation.
- Climate change impacts on livestock and animal health
- Enhancing understanding of climate change adaptation and mitigation strategies currently available
- The One Health approach
- Risk analyses, disease modeling, and prediction
- Facilitate knowledge exchange across countries and strengthen international networking to accelerate shared learning, innovation, and collaboration
- Identify shared regional challenges and actionable solutions

3. Methodology and approach

The workshop adopted a participatory, multidisciplinary approach, combining:

- Technical presentations and expert-led sessions
- Interactive discussions and panel dialogues
- Group-based synthesis and lesson development
- Field visits to research and production facilities
- Research presentations from AABCF Fellows

This approach ensured that outputs were analytical, actionable, and policy-relevant, rather than descriptive.

4. Technical findings

4.1 Climate change and animal health (One Health)

Climate change is reshaping disease dynamics through 1) Changes in temperature, humidity, and rainfall patterns, 2) Expansion of vector habitats and 3) Increased frequency of extreme events

These changes are driving emergence of new diseases, re-emergence of previously controlled diseases and expansion of zoonotic risks

The One Health framework was emphasized as essential for addressing these interconnected risks. However, implementation remains constrained by institutional fragmentation and limited cross-sector coordination.

4.2 Emerging and re-emerging diseases

Participants highlighted the growing threat of zoonotic diseases, transboundary animal diseases and climate-sensitive disease outbreaks. The key drivers include climate change, globalization and trade and land-use changes

The increasing complexity of disease dynamics requires stronger surveillance systems, integrated risk assessment frameworks and cross-border collaboration

4.3 Risk analysis and disease prediction

The workshop strengthened capacity in hazard identification, risk assessment and management and spatial disease mapping using GIS. Climate-informed disease prediction tools were presented as critical for early warning systems, strategic planning and resource allocation

However, limitations remain in predicting novel disease emergence, highlighting the need for improved data systems.

4.4 Climate-smart livestock systems

Climate-smart livestock systems are built on three pillars including productivity, adaptation and genetic fitness and mitigation, underpinned by the sustainable use of available resources. A key insight was the need to align farmer priorities (productivity and income) and scientific priorities (sustainability and emissions reduction).

Intervention areas include but not limited to 1) Animal health, 2) Feed and forage systems, 3) Genetics and breeding and 4) Climate risk management.

4.5 Livestock waste management and emissions

Livestock waste contributes significantly to methane, nitrous oxide and ammonia. Mitigation strategies include improved feeding practices, efficient manure management, biogas systems and use of additives such as biochar.

A critical finding is that management practices, not technology availability, are the primary constraint to reducing emissions.

4.6 Genomics and precision livestock systems

Emerging technologies provide transformative opportunities. These include improved systems to readily capture and store individual animal performance (phenotypic) information and portable DNA sequencing and microbiome analysis. These underpin the development and validation of appropriate genetic tools such as genomic selection, marker-assisted breeding, and resilience-focused breeding indices.

These tools enable breeding for resilience, improved disease detection and enhanced productivity and efficiency. However, adoption is limited by infrastructure gaps, high costs and limited technical capacity.

5. Field visit findings (Vietnam case studies)

5.1 Ba Vi Cattle and Forage Research Centre

The visit to the Ba Vi Centre highlighted the importance of integrated crop-livestock systems in improving productivity and resilience. Crop residues are efficiently used as livestock feed, while manure is recycled to enhance soil fertility, creating a circular and resource-efficient system. This integration reduces dependency on external inputs and strengthens resilience to climate variability.

A key focus is climate-resilient forage development, including high-yield grasses and leguminous species adapted to local conditions. These forages ensure year-round feed availability, improve diet quality, and enhance livestock productivity while reducing pressure on natural grazing systems. Improved feeding also contributes to lower emissions intensity per unit of output.

The centre serves as a research-to-extension hub, linking scientific innovation with farmer adoption through demonstration plots and training programs. This model emphasizes that effective scaling depends on strong extension systems and farmer engagement.

5.2 MONCADA Frozen Semen Research and Production Station

The MONCADA Station demonstrated the role of advanced breeding technologies in accelerating livestock improvement. Through strategic partnerships and genetic material exchange, genetic selection and controlled breeding, the station promotes traits such as productivity, disease resistance, and climate adaptability.

Artificial insemination (AI) enables rapid dissemination of superior genetics, improving herd performance while reducing the need for on-farm breeding males. Advanced semen processing and cryopreservation ensure high-quality genetic material and long-term storage.

Strict quality control and traceability systems enhance reliability and support national breeding programs, making improved genetics accessible to smallholder farmers.

Key insight: The field visit demonstrated that feed systems and genetic improvement are complementary drivers of sustainable livestock transformation, supported by strong research-extension linkages and institutional capacity. The opportunity exists to strengthen the breeding centre's position as a national platform for producing and disseminating climate-smart tropical beef genetics through strong research and extension pathways.

6. Country case studies challenges

6.1: Laos PDR

Key challenges in Laos can be categorized as follow:

- Biological & environmental challenges including 1) Heat stress leading to reduced productivity (meat, milk, eggs), 2) Flooding & drought increasing disease outbreaks (e.g., FMD, Lumpy Skin Disease)
- Technical challenges including 1) Limited or weak veterinary services, 2) Low-quality feed leading to feed shortages, 3) Seasonal feed scarcity (especially during dry season), 4) High input costs (especially imported animal feed)
- Economic barriers including: 1) Limited access to finance (credit constraints, high interest rates) and 2) Information and capacity gaps among farmers

Strategic direction: Strengthening services and local feed systems

6.2. Cambodia

Key Challenges in Cambodia include: 1) Climate change affecting livestock systems (floods, droughts, heat stress), 2) Disease outbreaks impacting animal health, 3) Weak veterinary and extension services, 4) Limited access to quality inputs (feed, breeding stock), 5) Market access constraints, 6) Financial limitations for farmers and 7) Technology adoption gaps

Strategic direction: Integrated support to include technology, finance and capacity building

6.3. Vietnam

Key challenges in Vietnam include: 1) Climate variability (drought, flooding, seasonal instability), 2) Feed availability and cost issues, 3) Disease risks and animal health challenges, 4) Weak integration across value chains, 5) Limited access to improved technologies, 6) Environmental pressures from livestock production and 7) Infrastructure and market system inefficiencies

Strategic direction: Sustainable intensification and improved market integration

7. Cross-cutting challenges

Across all countries the following challenges have been identified and include: 1) Climate variability and extreme events, 2) Weak surveillance and data systems, 3) Limited access to finance and technology, 4) Fragmented governance structures and 5) Low adoption of innovations

Round – table discussions:

1. What are the key challenges in your country around climate smart - livestock resilience ?



Picture 1: Climate-smart livestock resilience key challenges highlighted by Vietnam, Cambodia and Laos

8. Lessons learned from the Southeast Asia stakeholder consultation workshop

Key lessons learned are 6 folds and include: 1) Climate change is a system-wide risk multiplier, 2) One Health is essential but under-implemented, 3) Data and surveillance gaps limit effectiveness, 4) Smallholder constraints must be central to solutions, 5) Regional collaboration enhances innovation and scalability and 6) Lessons must translate into actionable solutions.

The challenges highlighted above and the lessons learnt are key points that will inform the design of the next solution to support the Southeast Asian region through the fellowship. Hence the following recommendations

9. Strategic Recommendations and regional implications

To enable more targeted intervention, the stakeholder consultation workshop clearly identified the key sectors to which the recommendations should be addressed. These recommendations cover policy, research, investment and capacity building.

Policy: There is a need for global intervention to strengthen One Health frameworks and improve cross-sector coordination

Research: Invest in data systems and modeling and promote applied and scalable innovations

Investment: Design investment-ready livestock projects that unlock public and private capital, tap into non-traditional donors, and drive innovative financing through the development of livestock innovations with high market shares

Capacity building: Strengthen extension systems and build technical skills across stakeholders

The workshop highlighted the need for: 1) Coordinated regional livestock strategies, 2) Shared data systems and knowledge platforms and 3) Stronger Africa-Asia partnerships

10. Way Forward and Conclusion

Key action points will consist to: 1) Develop regional and national action plans focusing on methods to improve climate change adaptation and methods to improve climate change mitigation, 2) Further strengthen collaborative partnerships between ILRI, the University of Queensland and the University of Melbourne, 3) Promote evidence-based decision-making, informed by past and current studies and 4) Expand collaborative research initiatives that complement ongoing and future initiatives

The AABCF workshop demonstrated that sustainable livestock transformation requires integrated, systems-based approaches that connect climate change, animal health and food systems

Success will depend on strong leadership, coordinated policies, strategic investments and sustained collaboration

11. Acknowledgment

The organizers of the Africa-Asia Biosciences Challenge Fund Southeast Asia Stakeholder Consultation Workshop, held in Hanoi from 23-27 March 2026, extend their heartfelt appreciation to all participants and partner institutions whose expertise and commitment made this gathering truly impactful. They allowed together a dynamic network of universities, national research organizations, government ministries, international research institutes, development partners, and AABCF fellows from across Asia, making the workshop a vibrant platform for dialogue and co-creation.

Their energy, insight, and collaborative spirit demonstrated throughout were pivotal in shaping the vision, priorities, and future partnerships that will drive the AABCF initiative forward.

We gratefully acknowledge the participation and support of representatives from the following institutions:

- Vietnam Animal and Veterinary Sciences (VIAVS)
- Vietnam Institute of Animal and Veterinary Science
- VAAS/ Institute of Agriculture Environment
- Vietnam National University of Agriculture

- Can Tho University, Vietnam
- Nong Lam University HCM, Vietnam
- Thai Nguyen University of Agriculture and Forestry, Vietnam
- National University of Laos (NUoL)
- National Agriculture and Forestry Research Institute, Laos
- National Animal Health and Production Research Institute, General Directorate of Animal Health and Production, Cambodia
- Livestock Development for Community Livelihood, Cambodia
- National University of Battambang, Cambodia
- University of Melbourne
- The University of Queensland
- Australian Centre for International Agricultural Research, Vietnam
- Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry,
- Australian Embassy in Vietnam
- International Livestock Research Institute

We also extend our sincere appreciation to the AABCF Fellows from Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos, whose participation enriched the discussions with practical perspectives from diverse livestock production systems.

Special thanks are due to the facilitator and organizers from the International Livestock Research Institute-Vietnam and partner institutions for their leadership in convening this important consultation and fostering collaboration across regions

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Annex 1: Summary of Welcome Remarks

- **Shirley Tarawali** (Picture 2-C) Emphasized the importance of Africa-Asia collaboration in addressing livestock and climate challenges, highlighting ILRI's role in advancing research partnerships and capacity building.
- **Tran Nam Anh** (Picture 2-B) Reaffirmed ACIAR's commitment to supporting international agricultural research, strengthening scientific networks, and promoting practical innovations for food security.
- **Ngo Thi Kim Cuc** (Picture 2-A) Welcomed participants to Vietnam and underscored the value of regional cooperation in advancing animal health, productivity, and sustainable livestock systems.
- **Nasser Yao** (Picture 2-D) Highlighted the objectives of the AABCF program, focusing on capacity development, knowledge exchange, and empowering fellows to drive impactful research in their home countries.



Figure 2: Pictorials drawn from the welcome remarks by: A-The Deputy Director General, Vietnam Animal and Veterinary Sciences (VIAVS), B-The Country Manager, ACIAR Vietnam, C- The Assistant Director General, ILRI and D) The PI of the AABCF project

Monica Finlayson, in her closing remarks, highlighted the value of the Africa-Asia Biosciences Challenge Fund workshop in fostering collaboration between Africa and Southeast Asia on climate-resilient livestock systems. She emphasized shared priorities such as productivity, animal health, genetics, nutrition, and data-driven innovation. She reaffirmed Australia's support through

Australian Centre for International Agricultural Research and praised partnerships involving International Livestock Research Institute and leading Australian universities such as UoM and UQ. She commended fellows for their engagement and encouraged continued collaboration, knowledge sharing, and joint research to address livestock challenges and strengthen sustainable agricultural systems beyond the workshop.



Figure 3: Monica Finlayson, the Agriculture Counsellor for Vietnam, Cambodia & Laos, Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Australian Embassy delivering her closing remarks

Annex 2: AABCF Southeast Asia Stakeholder Consultation Workshop Agenda

Day 1: Monday 23 March 2026	
Theme: “Foundations of Climate-Smart Livestock: Productivity, Health and Data-Driven Improvement”	
Morning session	
Facilitator: Tsehay Gashaw, Communication Advocacy & Knowledge Management (CAKM)	
08:00-09:00	Registration
09:00-10:00	Welcome remarks • Dr Shirley Tarawali, Asst. Director General (Asst. Director General), ILRI • Mr. Tran Nam Anh, Country Manager, ACIAR Vietnam • Ass. Prof Dr Ngo Thi Kim Cuc, Deputy Director General, Vietnam Animal and Veterinary Sciences (VIAVS) • Nasser Yao (Beca-ILRI Hub), Overview of the AABCF project and objectives of the workshop • Participants introduction, Tsehay Gashaw
10:00-10:45	Climate change and environmental impacts on animal performance <i>Dr Surinder Chauhan, UoM-SAFES</i>
10:45-11:10	Group photo & coffee break
11:10-11:45	Optimising Beef Production: Strategic levers and Performance Indicators. Learnings from Southeast Asia <i>Kieren McCosker, UQ</i>
11:45-13:00	<i>Round-table discussions</i>
13:00-14:00	Lunch break
Afternoon session	
14:00-14:45	Methane production and intensity <i>Dr Richard Eckard, UoM-SAFES and Dr Sarah Meale, UQ</i>
14:45-15:30	Climate change/disasters and animal health <i>Dr Abdul Jabbar, UoM-MVS</i>
15:30-16:00	Coffee break
16:00-16:45	Animal health and productivity resilience problem solving <i>Dr Mark Stevenson, UoM-MVS</i>
Day 2: Tuesday, 24 March 2026	
Building a shared understanding for livestock transformation in Asia and the Pacific	
08:00-08:30	Registration
Session 1: Opening	
Moderator: International Cooperation Department (ICD), Ministry of Agriculture & Environment (MAE)	
08:30-08:40	Introduction & Conference Objectives Leader, ICD

08:40-09:20	Opening remarks - Leader, MAE - Siboniso Moyo, Deputy Director General, ILRI - Assistant Director General, FAO RAP (video recording) - Olivier Brochet, French Ambassador to Vietnam MoU signing between ILRI, CIRAD and partners (5 min)
Session 2: Setting the scene – regional livestock systems in Asia and the Pacific and global challenges of livestock transformation Moderator: Felix Teillard (FAO)	
09:20-09:40	Keynote: Strategic overview of Asia's Livestock Systems and Global Action Plan for Livestock System Transformation, Food System Transformation in GPA - Shirley Tarawali, Assistant Director General, ILRI - Thanawat Tiensin, Assistant Director General, FAO
09:40-10:25	Thematic insights across four livestock priority areas • Role of livestock in Food Security and Nutrition • Livestock contributions to livelihoods • Animal Health & One Health • Climate & Environment Presenters: Dr Scott Newman (FAO), Dr Melanie Blanchard (CIRAD), Dr Jakob Zinsstag (Swiss Tropical and Public Health Institute), Dr Anthony Whitbread (ILRI) Q&A
10:25-10:45	Group photo and coffee break
Session 3: What vision for the region – Country and Regional perspectives on sustainable livestock transformation	
10:45-11:45	Panel discussion 1: Country perspectives panel to identify challenges, priorities and regional blockages • Vision for livestock sector • Priorities and challenges • One big solution relevant to your country and region Moderator: Dr Siboniso Moyo, DDG, ILRI Panellists: DGs from Livestock Department (Pacific region, Southeast Asia, South Asia)
11:45-12:30	Panel discussion 2: Regional perspective to discuss strategies responding to country challenges Moderator: Dr Scott Newman, FAO Panellists: Representatives from ASWGL, SAARC, SEARCA, APHCA, PHOVAPS
12:30-14:00	Lunch combined with marketplace
Session 4: Marketplace exchange	
14:00-15:00	Structured marketplace showcasing initiatives, programs, and solutions – towards cataloguing what are happening in the region. Collecting innovative solutions from countries and region – to be used later in an Atlas of livestock transformation solutions

15:00-15:30	Coffee break
Session 5: What vision for the region – Turning challenges into action	
15:30-15:40	Plenary briefing on objectives and methodology of the session Michael Victor, ILRI
15:40-17:45	Parallel sessions around four action areas: 1. One Health in agrifood systems 2. Climate-smart livestock 3. Livelihoods 4. Role of livestock in Food security and nutrition Prepare report back Facilitated parallel group discussions in separate rooms (25-30 pax per session) to identify priority actions, roles, and recommendations.
18:00-21:00	Conference dinner & partnership celebration

Day 3: Wednesday, 25 March 2026	
Theme: “Optimizing Livestock Nutrition, Genetics and Management for Climate-Smart and Low-Emission Production Systems”	
08:00-08:30	Registration
Morning session	
08:30-09:15	What is climate-smart livestock (CSL)? How does CSL link to other sustainable development themes? Examples of climate change case studies in East Africa and Southeast Asia <i>Dr Anthony Whitbread, Program Leader, Livestock, Climate and Environment, ILRI</i>
9:30-10:00	Optimising pasture use in Free-Grazing Cattle Systems: Insights from northern Australia <i>Dr Kieren McCosker, UQ</i>
10:00-10:45	Climate resilience small ruminant (sheep and goat) production <i>Dr Kristy DiGiacomo, UoM-SAFES</i>
10:45-11:15	Coffee break
11:15-12:00	Nutritional interventions for amelioration of heat stress <i>Dr Frank Dunshea, UoM-SAFES</i>
12:00-13:15	Lunch break
Afternoon session	
13:15-14:00	Using technology to advance understanding of heat tolerance in grazing cattle <i>Dr Angela Lees, UQ</i>
14:00-14:45	Portable Sequencing for Climate-Smart Livestock: Aging, Parental testing, Breeding, Disease Detection, and Methane Mitigation <i>Dr Loan Nguyen, UQ</i>
14:45-15:30	Coffee break
15:30-17:00	Round-table discussion (ILRI, UoM, UQ)

Day 4: Thursday, 26 March 2026	
Theme: Field visit to experience research models, technological innovations, and sustainable livestock farming practices in Vietnam	
08:00	Departure from Pan Pacific Hanoi Hotel, 1 Thanh Nien road, Ba Dinh ward, Hanoi. Delegates will be divided into two groups, each visiting the two sites in turn.
09:30-10:30	Field site visit - Group 1: Visit Ba Vi Cattle and Forage Research Centre - Group 2: Visit MONCADA Frozen Semen Research and Production Station
10:30-11:45	Site rotation - The two groups switch locations to visit the alternate site
11:45-13:30	Lunch at La Co Restaurant – Ba Vi (all participants)
13:30-15:00	Return to Hanoi (Pan Pacific Hotel), end of program

Day 5: Friday, 27 March 2026	
Theme “Building Climate-Resilient and Sustainable Livestock Systems for Improved Animal Health & Productivity”	
08:00-08:30	Registration
Morning session	
08:30-10:30	Tools and techniques for resilience preparation: geographic Information Systems – the key things you need to know; spatial data (raster, vector) formats; and predictive modelling of vector-borne diseases <i>Dr Abdul Jabbar and Dr Mark Stevenson, UoM-MVS</i>
10:30-11:00	Coffee break
11:00-12:30	Round-table discussion (ILRI, UoM, UQ)
12:30-13:30	Lunch break
Afternoon session	
13:30-14:10	SE Asia AABCF fellows’ presentations
14:10-15:00	Round- table discussions (ILRI, UoM, UQ)
15:00-15:30	Coffee break
15:30-15:45	Wrap up and next steps <i>Nasser Yao, ILRI</i>
15:45-16:00	Closing remarks Monica Finlayson, Agriculture Counsellor Vietnam, Cambodia & Laos, Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Australian Embassy

Annex 3: List of participants

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